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COMPARATIVE POLITICS

Session 03. Regimes and how we measure them.

THU 01 OCT 2026

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QUIZ 1 · 20 MINUTES

Quiz First

COVERS

Sessions 01 and 02. Lijphart 1971, Tilly 1985, and Hanson and Sigman 2021.

FORMAT

Ten questions. Single choice, select all that apply, and statements to correct.

RULES

Closed book. Phones and laptops away. Write your name at the top of the sheet.

Your best four of the six quizzes count. **Pens down when time is called.**

PREVIOUSLY

Last week, this week

SESSION 02

- Tilly on war, protection and extraction as the makers of states
- Hanson and Sigman on measuring state capacity and testing the measure

SESSION 03

- Levitsky and Way on regimes that hold real elections and still tilt the field
- Munck and Verkuilen on how democracy indices are built and where they fall short
- One group exercise

Last week we measured what states can do. **This week we ask who governs them, and by what rules.**

OPENER · ANY VOLUNTEERS?

One question before the readings

A country holds regular multiparty elections, and the opposition sometimes wins. Is it a democracy?

01

What else would you need to know before you answer?

02

Who draws the line, and with what evidence?

03

Would two democracy indices give the same answer?

LEVITSKY AND WAY 2002

What is wrong with "hybrid"?

DEMOCRATIZING BIAS

Scholars read mixed regimes as incomplete democracies still in transition. Mexico, Senegal and Taiwan did democratize in the 1990s. Azerbaijan and Belarus moved toward authoritarianism, and Malaysia, Russia, Ukraine, Zambia and Zimbabwe stayed put or moved in several directions.

RESIDUAL CATEGORIES

Freedom House rated El Salvador, Latvia and Ukraine "Partly Free" in 1992-93, each with a combined score of six.

- LATVIA** No citizenship for people of Russian descent
- EL SALVADOR** Human rights violations and no civilian control of the military
- UKRAINE** Civil liberties violated and procedures abused by incumbents

"It may therefore be time to stop thinking of these cases in terms of transitions to democracy and to begin thinking about the specific types of regimes they actually are."

Four minimum criteria

01

Free elections

Open, free and fair elections choose the executive and the legislature.

02

Universal suffrage

Virtually all adults have the right to vote.

03

Rights and liberties

Press freedom, freedom of association and the freedom to criticize the government without reprisal are broadly protected.

04

Real authority

Elected officials govern free of tutelary control by military or clerical leaders.

Democracies break these rules at times too. **In a competitive authoritarian regime the violations are frequent and serious enough to tilt the playing field.**

LEVITSKY AND WAY · DEFINITION

Between two borders

FULL AUTHORITARIANISM

Elections are absent or noncompetitive. Cuba and China ban competition by law, Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan in practice. Façade electoral regimes such as Egypt and Singapore in the 1990s belong here too.

RULE OF THUMB

A president reelected with more than 70 percent

COMPETITIVE AUTHORITARIANISM

Democratic institutions are the main route to power, and incumbents abuse them often enough to fail the minimum standards. Croatia under Tudjman, Serbia under Milošević, Russia under Putin, Peru under Fujimori.

DEMOCRACY

All four criteria hold. Flawed democracies stay on this side, such as O'Donnell's delegative democracies in Argentina and Brazil in the early 1990s. Peru after Fujimori's 1992 self-coup falls outside.

Following Linz, Levitsky and Way treat these regimes as **a diminished form of authoritarianism**.

Where the opposition fights back

ELECTIONS

Bitterly fought and mostly free of massive fraud. Kuchma took 35 percent in the first round in 1999. Opposition forces beat incumbents in Nicaragua in 1990, Zambia in 1991 and Ghana in 2000.

LEGISLATURE

Usually weak, sometimes a focal point. Ukraine's parliament blocked Kuchma's referendum to cut its powers, and an opposition deputy used it to release damaging tapes of the president.

JUDICIARY

When Russia's Constitutional Court ruled against his 1993 decree, Yeltsin cut its phone lines and took away its guards. Maverick judges still ruled against governments in Slovakia, Serbia and Malaysia.

MEDIA

Independent outlets are legal and often influential. Governments answer with bribes, state advertising, debts, taxes and libel suits. Croatia's major independent papers faced more than 230 libel suits by 1997.

Incumbents prefer "legal" harassment through tax authorities, compliant courts and libel law. **Open repression costs more while the rules still matter.**

The incumbent's dilemma

CRACK DOWN

Pay with international isolation and domestic conflict.

LET THE CHALLENGE RUN

Risk losing power.

Either way the result is often a regime crisis, as in Mexico in 1988, Russia in 1993, and Peru, Serbia and Ukraine in 2000.

Croatia, Nicaragua, Peru, Slovakia and Serbia democratized after turnover. **New leaders in Albania, Zambia, Ukraine and Belarus kept or intensified the old practices.**

OUTCOME

CASES

Weathered the storm

Kenya, Malaysia, Russia, Ukraine

Held back and lost

Nicaragua 1990, Zambia 1991, Ghana and Mexico 2000

Cracked down, then fell

Peru, Serbia

"But succession is not democratization."

LEVITSKY AND WAY · AFTER 1990

Ties to the West

4 of 5

Competitive authoritarian regimes in Latin America that democratized after 1990. The Dominican Republic, Mexico, Nicaragua and Peru did. Haiti did not.

4 of 5

The same count in Central Europe. Croatia, Serbia, Slovakia and Romania did. Albania did not.

1

Former Soviet republic whose competitive authoritarian regime democratized in the 1990s, Moldova.

Cultural and media influence, elite networks and Western pressure raised the cost of entrenchment. **Where Russia or China held sway, these regimes tended to persist or harden.**

LEVITSKY AND WAY · ORIGINS

Three paths, one decade

AUTHORITARIAN DECAY

Economic crisis and outside pressure pushed established autocrats to call multiparty elections. Weak oppositions let many of them keep power. Much of sub-Saharan Africa.

AUTHORITARIAN COLLAPSE

Weak electoral regimes emerged by default after a breakdown. Governments ruled autocratically and lacked the capacity to consolidate. Armenia, Croatia, Romania, Russia, Serbia, Ukraine, and Haiti after 1994.

DEMOCRATIC DECAY

Elected governments undermined institutions through a self-coup or piecemeal abuse, and lacked the will or capacity to remove them entirely. Peru in the early 1990s, and perhaps Venezuela.

"Pluralism and democratic contestation persisted less because elites wanted them than because elites simply could not get rid of them."

MUNCK AND VERKUILEN 2002

Three challenges, in order

Conceptualization



Measurement



Aggregation

CONCEPTUALIZATION

TASK

Pick the attributes and arrange them by level of abstraction

STANDARD

Avoid maximalist and minimalist definitions, redundancy and conflation

MEASUREMENT

TASK

Choose indicators and a measurement level, and publish the coding rules

STANDARD

Validity, reliability and replicability

AGGREGATION

TASK

Decide whether to combine the scores, how far, and by what rule

STANDARD

Validity, robustness and replicability

"Problems of causal inference have overshadowed the equally important problems of conceptualization and measurement."

Too little or too much

◀ MINIMALIST

MAXIMALIST ▶

TOO LITTLE

A missing attribute

Polity omits participation, so its data back to 1800 miss the slow spread of the vote. Coppedge and Reinicke, Gasiorowski and Vanhanen omit offices.

WHAT THEY LOOK FOR

Four attributes

Dahl's contestation and participation, plus whether key offices are filled by election and whether elected officials hold agenda-setting power.

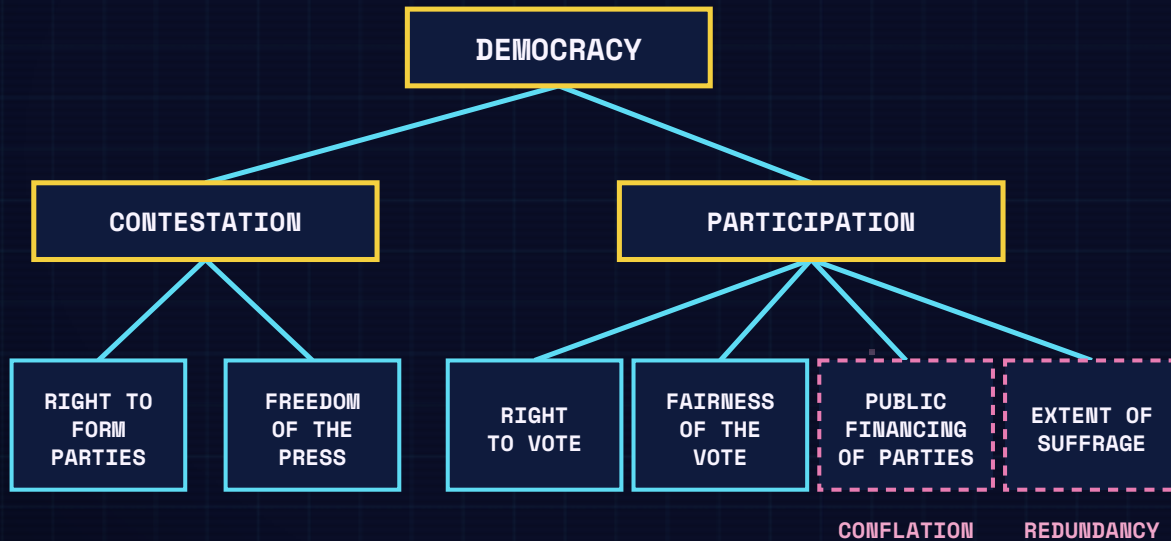
TOO MUCH

Borrowed attributes

Freedom House counts socioeconomic rights, freedom from gross inequality, property rights and freedom from war, which belong to other concepts.

Put markets into the definition of democracy and the link between the two is settled in advance. Some questions are **"just too interesting to be resolved by a definitional fiat."**

The concept tree



01 Leaves are the most concrete attributes. Measurement starts from them.

02 Conflation puts an attribute on the wrong branch. Public financing of parties concerns contestation.

03 Redundancy lets two attributes on one level cover the same ground. Extent of suffrage repeats the right to vote.

04 Polity IV splits two single issues into pairs of attributes. Freedom House lists 9 and 13 components as a "checklist."

From leaves to numbers

INDICATORS

Use several indicators and show they mean the same thing across countries. Watch for bias in the record. More reported corruption may only reflect a freer press.

MEASUREMENT LEVEL

Nominal, ordinal or interval, chosen to keep cases in a class alike with as few distinctions as needed. Bollen called democracy "continuous," and Alvarez and coauthors called that view "ludicrous."

RELIABILITY

Different coders give the same scores. Only Coppedge and Reinicke and Polity IV used several coders and tested their agreement. "Reliable measures need not be valid ones."

REPLICABILITY

Publish the coding rules, the coding process and the disaggregate data. Freedom House offered no coding rules, vague sources and no disaggregate data, so its scores are "accepted largely on faith."

MUNCK AND VERKUILEN · AGGREGATION

Add or multiply?

- 01 State how the attributes relate before you choose a rule.
- 02 Equal weight, so add. High participation can make up for low contestation.
- 03 Both necessary, so multiply. A low score on either one drags the total down.
- 04 Either one sufficient, so take the higher score.

TWO INVENTED COUNTRIES

	CONTESTATION	PARTICIPATION	ADD	MULTIPLY
Country A	0.9	0.1	1.0	0.09
Country B	0.5	0.5	1.0	0.25

Addition ranks them level. Multiplication puts B almost three times higher than A.

Freedom House adds its components, so decentralization weighs as much as the power of elected representatives. Most indices push straight to one score, which in Munck and Verkuilen's words **"puts the statistical cart before the theoretical horse."**

The scorecard

INDEX	STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
Polity IV	Offices and agenda setting, detailed coding rules, intercoder test, wide coverage	Omits participation, redundant attributes, poor aggregation
Freedom House	Covers the whole world	Maximalist, conflation, measurement problems, poor aggregation
ACLP	Offices, sound conceptual logic, good indicators, detailed coding rules	Omits participation and agenda setting
Hadenius	Offices, agenda setting and fairness, good indicators, sophisticated aggregation	Redundancy and conflation, a single year
Vanhanen	Clear coding rules, wide coverage, replicable	Omits offices and agenda setting, questionable indicators, poor aggregation

No index meets all three challenges. **The indices with the widest coverage are mostly among the weaker ones**, with Polity IV a partial exception.

What high correlations hide

- 01 The indices draw on the same sources, such as Arthur Banks's coded data, so they may share one bias.
- 02 Agreement between indices speaks to reliability. Validity needs evidence of its own.
- 03 Correlations of aggregate scores can hide a second dimension.

INDEX, 1973-1990	DIMENSION 1	DIMENSION 2
ACLP	-.93	-.18
Gasiorowski	.91	.26
Polity autocracy	-.96	-.27
Polity democracy	.95	.25
Freedom House civil liberties	-.57	.80
Freedom House political rights	-.56	.81
Share of variance	69%	26%

Freedom House loads heavily on a second dimension that the other indices barely touch. **Signs follow each index's coding direction.**

COMPARE THE READINGS

Two ways to study regimes

	LEVITSKY AND WAY 2002	MUNCK AND VERKUILEN 2002
Question	What kind of regime holds real elections and still tilts the field?	How well do existing indices measure democracy?
Move	Define a new regime type with clear borders	Judge nine indices against one framework
Evidence	Cases from Africa, Latin America, Asia and postcommunist Eurasia in the 1990s	Codebooks, and a principal components test on six series
Complaint	"Partly Free" lumps together regimes that differ	One score can hide several dimensions and a shared bias
Earlier sessions	Sartori's stretched concepts, as in calling every regime with elections a democracy	Hanson and Sigman tested for more than one dimension before settling on one score

Hanson and Sigman's Capacity correlates at .91 with the World Bank's government effectiveness index. **What would Munck and Verkuilen make of that evidence?**

GROUP EXERCISE · ADVISE THE AGENCY

A development agency sends your group one question

Our rules allow budget support only for democracies. Which of these four countries qualify?

COUNTRY A

Multiparty elections every five years, and observers found no massive fraud. The president won with 57 percent. His allies own the main TV channels, and tax inspectors audited two opposition newspapers before the vote. The constitutional court struck down one of his decrees.

COUNTRY B

Free and fair elections with high turnout, a free press and independent courts. A quarter of adult residents belong to a minority denied citizenship at independence, so they cannot vote.

COUNTRY C

Competitive elections, a free press and turnover in power. The armed forces appoint a fifth of the senate and can veto the defense budget.

COUNTRY D

The president was reelected with 91 percent. The main opposition party is banned, and international observers were refused entry.

- 01 Test each country against Levitsky and Way's four criteria. Which criterion does each one fail? Which country can be considered as a competitive authoritarian regime following Levitsky and Way's definition?
- 02 Build the agency's index. Score each country from 0 to 1 on **contestation** and on **participation**, then combine the two scores by adding and by multiplying. Which rule would you defend, and why?
- 03 Write a three-sentence memo that answers the agency and names one indicator to watch before Country A's next election.

The profiles are invented and describe no real country.

NEXT UP

Before Tuesday 6 October

Week 04. Democratization and democratic erosion.

READ

Acemoglu, Daron, and James A. Robinson. 2006.
Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy.
Cambridge University Press, chapter 2.

READ

Lührmann, Anna, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2019. "A Third
Wave of Autocratization Is Here. What Is New About It?"
Democratization 26(7), 1095-1113.



Tue 06 Oct

Week 4 class

M2170



Thu 08 Oct

No class



Thu 15 Oct

Quiz 2 opens the class



Tue 27 Oct

Complement on concepts, measurement and validity

M2170

PROGRESS SAVED

QUESTIONS?

Office hours Thursdays 14:30 to 16:00 in M4328

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BEFORE YOU LEAVE



Rate each group member's participation in today's exercise. **Required before you leave the room.**